

Scott Chiari
Prof. Baker
ENC 1101
9/28/2026

Kairos in Engineering Building II

The Engineering Building II is a large open room with tons of tables large enough to fit 10 and computers cluttered together in the middle. The room is loud as people converse their assignments. The room's primary purpose is a lobby to pass through to navigate to classrooms in the back of the building, but the inside the lobby, it promotes group focus, studying and networking. The space is used as a walk way, but also a study hub for students who share classes in the building, and seeing that it is indoors, the room doesn't encourage physical activities or people who are not there to accomplish something of importance. The lobby uses metal pipe to reflect the engineering themes of the building as well as its continued use of colors of metal and brick. The lobby has a display of rockets and an old Disney rollercoaster cart. The room feels large and open, it lets in much sunlight to illuminate the room, and then disguises its pillars as some kind of sparks as, what could be argued, trees. The room feels designed to make you feel in nature and the transition when entering the room reflects this as if it wants you to know you've left biological nature behind and are entering the world of artificial nature, an engineered one.

Ethos

While the space was designed with a specific intention by the rhetors of the space, what is acceptable inside it is determined by a new kind of rhetors: the people using the space. The people actively using the space create a new identity for themselves and everyone joining the space. The study area invites every person passing by to join in at a table and get some work done. The many round tables force people to look and engage with one another. The openness of the lobby ensures you are not hidden. The space naturally creates the identity of working hard and collaboration with those who use the space. The identity a space creates for those who experience it creates or destroys one's sense of belonging in it by displaying who has been in the building and what others currently occupying it are actively doing.

Upon entering the space, you instantly understand what it is you are meant to do in the space. When I entered the space to take pictures for this assignment, I immediately understood the lobby was not a place for casual loitering. Every person at a table had an assignment or project in front of them and were actively engaged in it with the people around them.

During the Knight Hacks event, the space told a completely different story. The space was not being used for studying or group collaboration, the space, in that moment, was meant to be used to allow mentees to meet mentors. With just a quick scan of a room, one can instantly understand what is acceptable in the space. When each table is crowding one person who is talking about their field, sitting down and doing an unrelated assignment on your laptop at the same table comes off as disruptive. Our idea of what and is not allowed in a space is determined by what others are actively using the space for.

This is known as ethos. Downs describes how we recognize ethos by stating “He suggested that rhetors get a sense of each others’ ethos in three ways: by assessing their expertise, their moral character, and their goodwill toward other rhetors – their willingness to put others’ interest first” (page 475) Although the lobby is designed to encourage group collaboration, the exact actions that are acceptable in a space are often determined by how others are currently using the space. In this way, those who use the space become the rhetors of the space in that moment.

Kairos

While the lobby is designed to be a place of collaboration, I found myself feeling excluded and uncomfortable exploring the lobby during my visit in the middle of the day. In the middle of the day, the room is the most crowded, every seat was taken by a focused individual, this made me feel out of place. So despite the room being designed to encourage people to linger, when the context of the room shifts to crowded, people just entering the space may feel out of place. This rhetoric is known as Kairos and can mean that the function of a space behaves differently based on what time and contexts a space is experienced.

My first experience was when I went to take pictures for this assignment when it was crowded, making me feel unwelcome. The space holds around 15 circular tables each with 10 chairs sat around them. A short walk around the space showed every single chair was taken. The only seats available were wedged between 2 actively engaged groups. After realizing I was unlikely to find a seat at one of the circular tables, I decided to look for an open desk at one of the many computers to possibly take a seat, of which every seat was also taken. This is when I left and decided the best place to do my work was in my dorm.

My second experience was when I went for the Knight Hacks club’s mentor meeting where the space was used to meet new people, making me feel very welcome, as I am in the club. The event took place at a later hour, meaning the space was less crowded. Despite this, I imagine that while I found comfort in the space during the event, those who were not part of the club did not.

Downs describes Kairos as a word that “translates to something like ‘timely good fortune’ or simply ‘lucky timing’ Kairos is the principle that rhetors have far from complete control of their texts and discourses , because circumstances beyond their

control can intervene to change the moment and what it makes sense to say in that moment.” (page 467) Rhetoric focuses on persuasion and convincing people of certain ideas; however, there will always be things a rhetor cannot control. As seen in the engineering building II’s lobby.

Bibliography

Doug Downs. *Chapter 4. "Making Sense of Human Interaction and Meaning"*. Published 2013.